

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, clouds and sun, high 56. To-
night, mostly cloudy, low 45. **Tomor-
row**, mostly cloudy, very warm,
some rain arriving toward evening,
high 64. Weather map, Page B12.

VOL. CLXXV No. 60,830

© 2026 The New York Times Company

SATURDAY, MARCH 21, 2026

Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



SAHER ALGHORRA FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Celebrating Eid al-Fitr in Gaza
Palestinians recited prayers on Friday beside the ruins of a mosque in central Gaza City. The Eid holiday marks the end of Ramadan.

Pentagon Restrictions on Press Unconstitutional, a Judge Rules

By ERIK WEMPLE

WASHINGTON — A federal judge on Friday ruled that the Pentagon’s restrictions on the news media violated the First Amendment and issued an order tossing parts of the department’s policy, handing a victory to The New York Times, which filed suit in December over the restrictions.

Judge Paul Friedman, of the U.S. District Court for the District of Columbia, also ordered the Pentagon to restore the press passes of seven journalists for The Times. They had surrendered those passes in October instead of signing the policy, which empowered the Pentagon to declare journalists

“security risks” and revoke their press passes if they engage in any conduct that the Pentagon believes threatens national security.

In his ruling, Judge Friedman wrote that the Pentagon’s policy rewarded reporters who were “willing to publish only stories that are favorable to or spoon-fed by Department leadership.”

Siding with an argument advanced by The Times, Judge Friedman added that the Pentagon had given itself too much power to enforce its new rules.

The ruling was a defeat for the Trump administration, which has

Continued on Page A15



THE CANNON GROUP/GOLAN GLOBUS PRODUCTIONS

Rescuing G.I.s from Vietnam in “Missing in Action” (1984).

CHUCK NORRIS, 1940-2026

Turned His Martial Arts Skills Into TV and Big Screen Gold

By CLYDE HABERMAN

Chuck Norris, who channeled his skills as a martial arts black belt into a durable acting career that left film critics largely unimpressed but delighted millions of fans savoring his good-guy triumphs and fortune-cookie musings, died on Thursday. He was 86.

His death was announced by his family through his official Instagram account, but no further details were immediately available. He was hospitalized earlier that day in Hawaii after experiencing a

medical emergency, the family said.

As an actor, Mr. Norris was well aware that no one would mistake him for a latter-day Laurence Olivier. In most of his films and in “Walker, Texas Ranger,” a CBS television series that ran from 1993 to 2001, he played a warrior who comes to the rescue not with words or guns but rather with spinning back kicks and other techniques that had made him a

Continued on Page A17

Trump Friend, in Custody Fight, Asked ICE to Hold Ex-Partner

This article is by Megan Twohey, Shawn McCreesh and Hamed Aleaziz.

Last June, the man credited with introducing President Trump to his wife asked the administration for a favor.

Paolo Zampolli, a former modeling agent turned presidential special envoy, had learned that his Brazilian ex-girlfriend was in a Miami jail, arrested on charges of fraud at her workplace. They had been in a custody battle over their teenage son. Now he saw an opportunity.

He reached out to a top official at Immigration and Customs Enforcement, explaining that his ex was in the country illegally, according to records obtained by The New York Times and a person familiar with the communications. Could she be put in ICE detention? That could help him get his son back.

The official, David Venturella, promptly called the agency’s Miami office to ensure that ICE agents would pick up the woman from the jail before she was released on bail, according to the records and a person with knowledge of the conversation who requested anonymity to discuss it. During the call, Mr. Venturella

Continued on Page A14

Exploiting the Levers of Government to Settle a Personal Score

noted that the case was important to someone close to the White House.

The woman, Amanda Ungaro, was placed in ICE custody and ultimately deported, an outcome that may well have happened regardless of Mr. Zampolli’s meddling. But the ICE official’s willingness to spring into action for a Trump ally — even one in a low-level, largely ceremonial role — reflects a recurring theme of the second Trump administration: The levers of the federal government can be pulled to settle a personal score.

Mr. Zampolli, 56, is known in Washington for flaunting his proximity to the Trumps. In this case, he used his clout to solicit help from an agency beset by allegations of unlawful overreach.

In an interview with The Times, Mr. Zampolli denied asking ICE to detain Ms. Ungaro or seeking any other favors. He said he merely asked Mr. Venturella to explain

Continued on Page A14

U.S. Steps Up Airstrikes To Try to Reopen Strait As Iran Chokes Oil Flow

Hegseth Frames War in Religious Terms

By GREG JAFFE and ELIZABETH DIAS

WASHINGTON — He spoke of “overwhelming force” and the U.S. military’s unmatched ability to rain “death and destruction from above” on its “apocalyptic” Iranian foes.

Then, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, standing in the Pentagon, issued a call to the American people for a specific kind of wartime prayer. He asked them to pray for victory in battle and the safety of their troops.

“Every day, on bended knee, with your family, in your schools, in your churches,” he said, “in the name of Jesus Christ.”

At a time when the U.S. and Israeli militaries are dropping thousands of bombs on a majority-Shiite Muslim nation, the explicitly Christian nature of Mr. Hegseth’s call stood out.

More than any top American military leader in recent history, Mr. Hegseth has framed U.S. military operations in the Middle East, Africa and Latin America as bigger than politics or foreign policy. Often he has imbued these actions with a Christian moral underpinning that suggests they are divinely sanctioned.

It is this view of a higher power, married to lethal American firepower, that Mr. Hegseth says gives him confidence that the United States will prevail in Iran.

“Our capabilities are better. Our will is better. Our troops are better,” he said in a recent interview with CBS News’s “60 Minutes.” “The providence of our almighty God is there protecting those troops, and we’re committed to this mission.”

At the same time, Mr. Hegseth has largely avoided casting Islam as the enemy. In a news conference on Thursday, he praised America’s Gulf Arab allies for supporting the war after Iran attacked them.

“We’re proud to be defending with them, standing with them,” Mr. Hegseth said.

The conservative branch of American Christianity that Mr. Hegseth represents has long been central to President Trump’s movement, and its ideas are frequently invoked by Mr. Trump and senior members of his administration.

“I was saved by God to make America great again,” Mr. Trump said at his 2025 inauguration, referencing a sense of divine mission after surviving an assassination attempt. And last month in Munich, Secretary of State Marco Ru-

Continued on Page A8

Clashing Signals by Trump on Plans

This article is by Adam Rasgon, Eric Schmitt, Francesca Regalado and Michael Levenson.

JERUSALEM — U.S. warplanes and attack helicopters have ramped up assaults against Iranian drones and naval vessels, American officials said, in an effort to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, the strategic waterway that Iran has effectively closed to most Western ships. The de facto blockade has helped drive up oil prices and rocked the global economy.

The intensified attacks came as the U.S.-Israeli war in Iran approached the three-week mark with no clear endgame or timeline outlined by American or Israeli leaders and a weakened Iran still firing missiles and drones at other countries in the Middle East.

Even as the United States was trying to force open the Strait of Hormuz, and planning to send additional troops to the region, President Trump sent a contradictory signal.

In a social media post on Friday, he said that the United States was “getting very close to meeting our objectives as we consider winding down” the military attack on Iran and that he would leave it up to other nations to protect the Strait of Hormuz.

Earlier on Friday, when asked by a reporter on the White House lawn about a possible cease-fire in the Middle East, Mr. Trump responded that there was no need for a truce with Iran. “I don’t want to do a cease-fire,” he said. “You know, you don’t do a cease-fire when you’re literally obliterating the other side.”

Israel said on Friday that it had launched strikes against targets in Tehran after Iranian missile fire set off sirens in Jerusalem and northern Israel overnight. The Israeli military, which has been systematically killing Iran’s leaders, said it had slain Ali Mohammad Naini, the spokesman for Iran’s Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps. The Guards confirmed he had been killed but did not give details.

Kuwait said that drone attacks had caused fires at an oil refinery for the second consecutive day. Those attacks, part of a series of Iranian strikes on oil and gas infrastructure in the region, have led to fears of lasting disruptions in global energy supplies.

Iran attacked energy sites this week, after Israel struck the South Pars natural gas field; it is shared by Qatar and is a major source of Iran’s domestic energy. Bahrain, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab

Continued on Page A8

As BTS Transitions From the Military, Recalling How Elvis Did It

By GAVIN EDWARDS

Some musicians thrive in the armed forces: James Blunt spent six years in the British Army before he started his singing career, rising to the rank of captain.

Some don’t: Jerry Garcia of the Grateful Dead was discharged by the U.S. Army after nine months for being “completely lacking in soldierly qualities.”

And some have no choice but to interrupt their meteoric rises to serve: The multiplatinum pop group BTS went on hiatus in 2022 so its seven members could complete their mandatory stints in the South Korean military.

By June of last year, all seven BTS singers had fulfilled their service, in roles including drill instructor, cook and public service worker. With their 10th studio album, “Arirang,” due Friday and a

Can Korean Pop Stars Emulate America’s Famous Draftee?

concert on Saturday livestreamed on Netflix, they will attempt to resume their careers as pop idols after being conscripted — a feat almost unprecedented, if not for Elvis Presley’s time in the Army.

When Presley was drafted at age 22, he was at the vanguard of rock ‘n’ roll. By the time he returned, his prospects seemed uncertain and rock was reeling. Little Richard had renounced secular music, Jerry Lee Lewis was mired in scandal after he married his 13-year-old cousin, and Buddy Holly, Ritchie Valens and the Big Bopper

Continued on Page A5



CHUNG SUNG-JUN/GETTY IMAGES

K-pop band BTS members RM, left, and V in Chuncheon, South Korea, after being discharged from mandatory military service.



NATIONAL A10-16

Colorado Meatpacking Strike
The action comes as beef prices have soared and immigration sweeps have stressed the labor supply. *PAGE A11*

Trump Sues Harvard
The administration had spent months investigating the school over allegations of antisemitism. *PAGE A13*

INTERNATIONAL A4-9

Possible Relief for Havana?
A Russian tanker laden with about 730,000 barrels of crude is being closely tracked to see if it will challenge the U.S. oil blockade on Cuba. *PAGE A7*

U.S. Query Targets Colombia
President Gustavo Petro is under criminal investigation by at least two U.S. federal prosecutors’ offices over possible ties to drug traffickers. *PAGE A7*

Ozempic Is Going Generic
In many nations, but not in the U.S., Novo Nordisk is losing patent protection for its weight loss drug, opening the door for cheaper versions. *PAGE A6*

ARTS C1-6

A.I. Is Writing Fiction
Book publishing has few safeguards in place to prevent the unwitting publication of a novel heavily generated by artificial intelligence. *PAGE C1*

Jazz Age Comes Alive
The musical “The Wild Party” revisits a tale of debauchery, with a steady stream of showstoppers. *PAGE C1*

TRAVEL C7-8

Peace Is Pricey in Paradise
At an all-inclusive resort on a private island in Turks and Caicos, tranquility is among the luxuries. *PAGE C7*

BUSINESS B1-7

The Agent Becomes the Talent
Ari Emanuel, a Hollywood archetype, shows a different side of himself as a host of a video podcast. *PAGE B1*



SPORTS B8-11

A March Star Is Born
Pryce Sandfort helped Nebraska to finally win a game in the men’s N.C.A.A. basketball tournament. *PAGE B8*

A Deal to Toast, for Now
The new W.N.B.A. labor pact means huge salary increases, but growth could soon outstrip the gains. *PAGE B10*

OPINION A18-19

Thomas L. Friedman *PAGE A18*

